

much of the same stock as he could, to sell to the broker for an exorbitant profit. Similarly, if the broker wanted to sell a big lot of shares, the 'robber' would sell ahead of him at a high price, and then buy the shares cheap from the broker.

Two such 'robbers', AS and PS, had earned notoriety for their practice of exploiting the counterparty at every opportunity. Funnily, AS and PS did not trust each other either. Occasionally, they would buy from and sell shares to each other. I was told that they would peek into each other's *sauda* pads to ensure that the correct details had been entered. And yet, many brokers dealt with them once in a while because AS and PS could procure or dispose of large blocks of shares. And because the duo had deep pockets and were big risk takers too, they could hold on to those positions for a few days or even weeks, till they found another counterparty to square up the trades.

Despite the combined curses of many a client weighing on them, AS and PS have done very well for themselves. Karma is yet to pay them a visit as I write this story.

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The trades done on the floor of the exchange had to be entered in the *sauda* pad. Every sheet in the *sauda* pad had five columns for five details about the deals – the clearing number of the broker one has dealt with, whether shares were bought or sold, the name of the stock, the quantity of shares, and the price at which the deal was done. Disputes would arise if one broker erred in recording the quantity of shares or the nature of the transaction (buy or sell) in his *sauda* pad. The stock exchange would then issue an objection memo, known as the *vaanda kaapli*, to the two members and ask them to sort out their disagreement. There was a deadline for resolution of the dispute, and the two parties would meet face to face to come to an agreement. In the majority of the cases, the two parties would know each other fairly well, so the resolution was rarely acrimonious. Sometimes you had to give an inch and sometimes you would get an inch.

Looking back, the manner in which disputes were settled in those days appears laughable. Sometimes, the broker who was in the right would produce witnesses who had been standing next to them as the disputed trade